

CHANGES IN SOCIAL PHYSIQUE ANXIETY DURING 16-WEEK PHYSICAL ACTIVITY COURSES¹

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Summary.—Social physique anxiety represents a discomfort or apprehension about body proportions, especially during social exercise. The purpose of this study was to describe the relationship for such anxiety with selection of differing types of physical activity courses, assess changes in social physique anxiety after a 16-wk. physical activity session, and examine sex differences in social physique anxiety. Data from 315 undergraduate students (217 women, 98 men) enrolled in either physical activity courses or an emergency care course showed those in a fitness course had higher anxiety scores. Such scores differed by sex, and showed improvement between 8 and 16 wk.

Findings are equivocal in evaluating whether the construct of social physique anxiety is strong enough to influence exercise behavior either through acquisitive or protective self-presentation. Researchers suggest such anxiety is associated with motives for exercise participation (3) and, consequently, seems to be related to affect and behavior in exercise settings, yet needs further study.

Sex has a significant influence on the complex relations among exercise, body image, and social physique anxiety (1, 4, 7). The relationship between social physique anxiety and exercise behavior (6) was moderated by both sex and age, with the least amount of exercise being performed by older women with high anxiety.

Binderwish (2) remarked that social physique anxiety played a critical role in college-age students' preferences for exercise settings. A sample of 375 undergraduates enrolled in a co-educational physical education course reported self-presentational concerns about their physique being negatively evaluated by others. This was thought to affect the choice in class selection, but no other studies to date were found. So, the purpose of this study was to describe the relations among social physique anxiety and selection of various types of physical activity courses to assess changes in such anxiety after a 16-wk. physical activity session, and to examine sex differences.

Method.—Data were obtained from 315 undergraduate students (217 women, 98 men) enrolled in either a physical activity course or an emergency care course. Students in jogging, aer-

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obic dance, and weight training classes ($n=140$) were considered to be in a fitness course, which emphasized strength and conditioning throughout the semester with the underlying goal of improvement of the students' fitness. Those in tennis, badminton, and racquetball courses ($n=98$) were considered to be in a skill course focused on skill acquisition in a sport through various drills and court time with additional emphasis on improved game play, but not on fitness. Seventy-seven students enrolled in an emergency care course served as the control group. This was a lecture-oriented class without physical activity. These students were not enrolled in any physical education activity course, an exclusion criterion extended to the prior term as well.

Social physique anxiety was assessed using the Social Physique Anxiety Scale (5), a 12-item self-report scale developed to assess how anxious people become when others observe or evaluate their physical appearance. For each item, participants indicate how much the statement is characteristic of them on a 5-point Likert scale with anchors of 1: not at all and 5: extremely. Adequate internal consistency ($\alpha = .89-.90$), construct validity, and predictive validity of the scale have been reported (5, 8) and for the present students was .87. Participants completed the scale at the beginning of the second regular class (baseline), at midsemester (8 wk.), and again on the last day of their regular course (16 wk.). Completion of the questionnaire took approximately 20 min. and was administered by the principal investigator. Approval to conduct the study was granted by the Institutional Review Board.

Results.—Table 1 presents the means and standard deviations for rated Social Physique Anxiety at baseline, 8 wk., and 16 wk. Repeated-measures analysis of variance specified mean sex differences at baseline ($p = .001$), 8 wk. ($p = .0001$), and 16 wk. ($p = .001$). Significant differences occurred at 16 wk. ($p = .05$) between the fitness and skill groups, and the fitness and control groups ($p = .05$). Rated Social Physique Anxiety scores decreased significantly from baseline to 16 wk. ($p = .002$).

TABLE 1
MEANS AND STANDARD DEVIATIONS FOR SOCIAL PHYSIQUE ANXIETY

Variable	Baseline		8 Weeks		16 Weeks	
	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>
Men	30.6	9.0	29.9	8.6	24.0	15.1
Women	38.9	8.3	37.9	8.7	33.8	13.2
Fitness Group	38.1	7.9	39.2	12.0	37.1	7.9
Skill Group	35.4	8.5	35.2	10.5	33.8	6.5
Control Group	34.5	12.6	35.9	10.4	32.8	9.8
Social Physique Anxiety (Fitness, Skill)	36.3	6.8	35.4	7.9	31.8	11.3

Significant differences for social physique anxiety between men and women showed at pre-test. Women scored more anxious; this supports other research (1, 4, 7). Furthermore, at 8 wk. and 16 wk. women still had higher mean scores than men.

Interestingly, changes in social physique anxiety did not appear until the 16-wk. test for combined skill and fitness classes. Social physique anxiety may be attributed to a more externally focused locus of control with emphasis placed on participants' belief about how others view their bodies, which may require time (16 wk.) to change. Finally, students' self-presentational concerns about their physiques being negatively evaluated by others may influence their anxiousness and take longer to change.

Social Physique Anxiety scores were not significantly different by class selection (fitness, skill, or control) at baseline, suggesting they might not have affected class choices by students.

The mean was significantly different at 16 wk. from the mean of those in fitness courses as these students had a significantly higher mean than those in skill classes and the control group.

Present findings support the literature suggesting women show higher Social Physique Anxiety scores. However, such anxiety did not affect the class selection, with significant changes in social physique anxiety occurring between 8 and 16 wk. of an activity class.

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